

JKBOSE

🔥 2026 CLASS 11th 🔥

Prose

ENGLISH

LECTURE-1

BY-HUSSAIN SIR



TOPICS TO BE COVERED

1 ... Detailed explanation of the Chapter

2 ... MCqs (as poll)

3 ...

4 ...

Khushwant Singh

Khushwant Singh was a renowned Indian author, lawyer, diplomat, journalist, and politician, best known for his sharp wit, secularism, and literary contributions. He's most famous for his historical novel **Train to Pakistan** (1956), which portrays the horrors of the Partition of India in 1947.

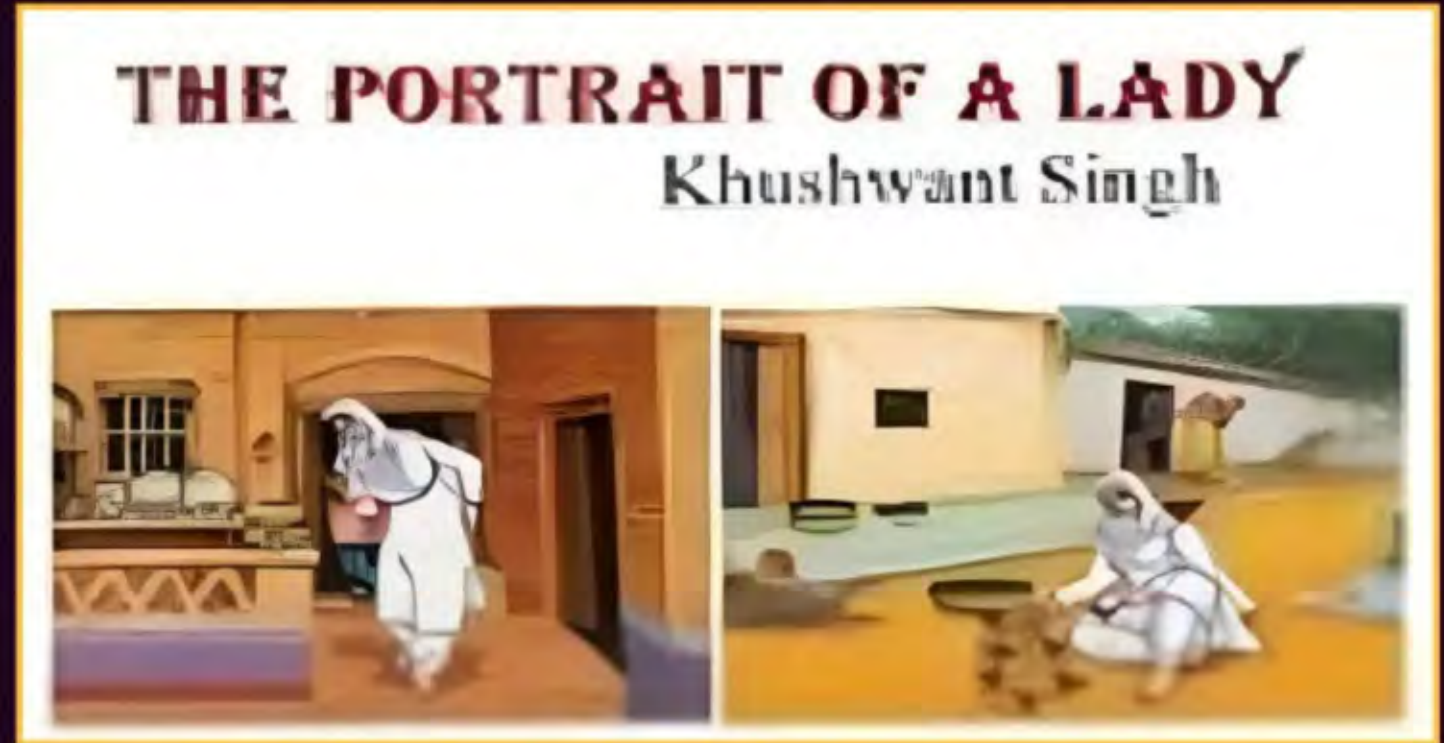
Born: February 2, 1915 | **Died:** March 20, 2014



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

"**The Portrait of a Lady**" is taken from Khushwant Singh's collection of autobiographical essays titled *The Portrait of a Lady: Collected Stories* (published in various editions). It's often included in anthologies of his short stories and essays.



The Portrait of a Lady

By ~ Khushwant Singh

→ Grandmother

→ It is written in first person.

The story is divided into three phases of the narrator's relationship with his grandmother:

1. Childhood (with grandmother):

The narrator lived with his grandmother in the village. She was deeply religious, always praying and counting her beads. She took care of him lovingly, walked him to school, and helped him with his studies. Their bond was very close.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

The story is divided into three phases of the narrator's relationship with his grandmother:

2. City life (drifting apart):

When they moved to the city, the narrator started attending an English-medium school. His grandmother could no longer help him with his education and disapproved of his modern, science-focused studies. Their interactions became limited, but she still prayed and fed birds daily.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

The story is divided into three phases of the narrator's relationship with his grandmother:

3. Old age and death:

Eventually, when the narrator went abroad for further studies, she did not show any emotion, only prayed for his well-being. Upon his return years later, she looked the same—aged but serene. She died peacefully soon after, and birds gathered around her body, not chirping, almost as if mourning.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

My grandmother, like everybody's grandmother, was an old woman. She had been old and wrinkled for the twenty years that I had known her. People said that she had once been young and pretty and had even had a husband, but that was hard to believe. My grandfather's portrait hung above the mantel piece in the drawing room. He wore a big turban and loose-fitting clothes. His long, white beard covered the best part of his chest and he looked at least a hundred years old. He did not look the sort of person who would have a wife or children.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

He looked as if he could only have lots and lots of. (many) grandchildren. As for my grandmother being young and pretty, the thought was almost revolting.

(It was very hard for the author to believe).

She often told us of the games she used to play as a child. That seemed quite absurd (illogical) and undignified (disrespectful) on her part and we treated it like the fables of the Prophets she used to tell us.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

She had always been short and fat and slightly bent. Her face was a criss-cross of wrinkles running from everywhere to everywhere. No, we were certain (sure) she had always been as we had known her. Old, so terribly old that she could not have grown older, and had stayed at the same age for twenty years. She could never have been pretty; but she was always beautiful. She hobbled (walked in an awkward way) about the house in spotless white with one hand resting on her waist to balance her stoop (bend one's body forward) and the other telling the beads of her rosary.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

Her ^{Hair} silver locks were scattered untidily over her pale, puckered face, and her lips constantly moved in inaudible (unable to be heard) prayer. Yes, she was beautiful. She was like the winter landscape in the mountains, an expanse of pure white serenity breathing peace and contentment (The state of being peaceful and calm)



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

My grandmother and I were good friends. My parents left me with her when they went to live in the city and we were constantly together. She used to wake me up in the morning and get me ready for school. She said her morning prayer in a monotonous sing-song while she bathed and dressed me in the hope that I would listen and get to know it by heart; I listened because I loved her voice but never bothered to learn it.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh



Then she would fetch my wooden slate which she had already washed and plastered with yellow chalk, a tiny earthen ink-pot and a red pen, tie them all in a bundle and hand it to me. After a breakfast of a thick, stale chapatti with a little butter and sugar spread on it, we went to school. She carried several stale chapattis with her for the village dogs.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh



My grandmother always went to school with me because the school was attached to the temple. The priest taught us the alphabet and the morning prayer. While the children sat in rows on either side of the verandah singing the alphabet or the prayer in a chorus, my grandmother sat inside reading the scriptures. When we had both finished, we would walk back together. This time the village dogs would meet us at the temple door. They followed us to our home growling and fighting with each other for the chapattis we threw to them.



QUESTION

What is the genre of the story?

1 Autobiographical sketch

2 Fantasy

3 Poetry

4 Fiction



QUESTION

Who is the central character of the story?

1 The author's mother ✗

2 The author's sister ✗

3 The author's teacher ✗

4 The author's grandmother ✓



QUESTION

How did the author describe his grandmother in the beginning?

- 1** Tall and beautiful ✗
- 2** Young and energetic ✗
- 3** Short, fat, and slightly bent ✓
- 4** Old and weak with a stick ✗



QUESTION

What did the grandmother always carry with her?

- 1 A rosary and a book
- 2 A rosary and feeding bowl
- 3 A walking stick and a book
- 4 A rosary and a walking stick



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

When my parents were comfortably settled in the city, they sent for us. That was a turning-point in our friendship. Although we shared the same room, my grandmother no longer came to school with me. I used to go to an English school in a motorbus. There were no dogs in the streets and she took to feeding sparrows in the courtyard of our city house.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

As the years rolled by we saw less of each other. For sometime she continued to wake me up and get me ready for school. When I came back she would ask me what the teacher had taught me. I would tell her English words and little things of western science and learning, the law of gravity, Archimedes' Principle, the world being round, etc. This made her unhappy.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

She could not help me with my lessons. She did not believe in the things they taught at the English school and was distressed that there was no teaching about God and the scriptures. One day I announced that we were being given music lessons. She was very disturbed. To her music had lewd associations. (indecent or obscene) It was the monopoly of harlots and beggars and not meant for gentlefolk. She said nothing but her silence meant disapproval. She rarely talked to me after that.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

When I went up to University, I was given a room of my own. The common link of friendship was snapped. My grandmother accepted her seclusion with resignation. She rarely left her spinning-wheel to talk to anyone. From sunrise to sunset she sat by her wheel spinning and reciting prayers. Only in the afternoon she relaxed for a while to feed the sparrows.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

While she sat in the verandah breaking the bread into little bits, hundreds of little birds collected round her creating a veritable bedlam of **chirrupings (noise of the birds)** Some came and perched on her legs, others on her shoulders. Some even sat on her head. She smiled but never shooed them away. It used to be the happiest half-hour of the day for her.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

When I decided to go abroad for further studies, I was sure my grandmother would be upset. I would be away for five years, and at her age one could never tell. But my grandmother could. She was not even sentimental. She came to leave me at the railway station but did not talk or show any emotion. Her lips moved in prayer, her mind was lost in prayer. Her fingers were busy telling the beads of her rosary. Silently she kissed my forehead, and when I left I cherished the moist imprint as perhaps the last sign of physical contact between us.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

But that was not so. After five years I came back home and was met by her at the station. She did not look a day older. She still had no time for words, and while she clasped me in her arms I could hear her reciting her prayers. Even on the first day of my arrival, her happiest moments were with her sparrows whom she fed longer and with frivolous rebukes.

(light hearted scolding)



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

In the evening a change came over her. She did not pray. She collected the women of the neighbourhood, got an old drum and started to sing. For several hours she thumped **the sagging skins of the dilapidated drum** and sang of the home-coming of warriors. We had to persuade her to stop to avoid overstraining. That was the first time since I had known her that she did not pray.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

The next morning she was taken ill. It was a mild fever and the doctor told us that it would go. But my grandmother thought differently. She told us that her end was near. She said that, since only a few hours before the close of the last chapter of her life she had omitted to pray, she was not going to waste anymore time talking to us.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

We protested. But she ignored our protests. She lay peacefully in bed praying and telling her beads. Even before we could suspect, her lips stopped moving and the rosary fell from her lifeless fingers. A peaceful pallor (an unhealthy pale appearance) spread on her face and we knew that she was dead.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh



We lifted her off the bed and, as is customary, laid her on the ground and covered her with a red shroud. After a few hours of mourning we left her alone to make arrangements for her funeral. In the evening we went to her room with a crude stretcher to take her to be cremated. The sun was setting and had lit her room and verandah with ablaze of golden light. We stopped half-way in the courtyard. All over the verandah and in her room right up to where she lay dead and stiff wrapped in the red shroud, thousands of sparrows sat scattered on the floor.



The Portrait of a Lady

By~ Khushwant Singh

There was no chirruping. We felt sorry for the birds and my mother fetched some bread for them. She broke it into little crumbs, the way my grandmother used to, and threw it to them. The sparrows took no notice of the bread. When we carried my grandmother's corpse off, they flew away quietly. Next morning the sweeper swept the bread crumbs into the dustbin.



QUESTION

What was the turning point in the relationship between the author and his grandmother?

1 When his parents moved to the city 

2 When he joined an English school 

3 When his grandfather died

4 When she fell ill



QUESTION

How did the grandmother spend her time when the author went abroad?

- 1** Teaching children *p*
- 2** Spinning the wheel and feeding sparrows ✓
- 3** Watching Television *p*
- 4** Visiting Nighbors *p*



QUESTION

What does the chapter mainly focus on?

- 1** Education
- 2** Rural Life
- 3** Relationship between author and his grandmother
- 4** Migration



QUESTION

What unusual sight did the family see after her death?

1

Rainfall



2

Flock of sparrows gathered in silence



3

A rainbow appeared



4

Dogs gathered



QUESTION

What emotion is conveyed by the sparrows' behavior?

- 1** Joy 
- 2** Fear 
- 3** Respect and mourning 
- 4** Excitement



**Thank
You**